



“THIS IS YOUR VICTORY! IT IS THE VICTORY OF THE CAUSE OF FREEDOM IN EVERY LAND.”

Winston Churchill in an address to the crowds in London, May 8, 1945

Exuberant Londoners celebrate on Victory in Europe (VE) Day, May 8, after the announcement of the final unconditional surrender of German forces.

IN FEBRUARY 1945, JOSEPH STALIN, FRANKLIN ROOSEVELT, AND WINSTON CHURCHILL met for the last time at a conference at **Yalta** in the Crimea. Stalin agreed to hold democratic elections in Poland—a promise he did not intend to keep. To aid the Soviet troops invading Germany from the east, the Western leaders agreed to step up bombing of German rail centers, including **Dresden**. On the night of February 13–14, Britain's RAF dropped explosive and incendiary bombs on Dresden, causing a firestorm that destroyed the city's historic center and killed some 25,000 people.

There was little pity for the Germans, as the **liberation of the death camps** exposed Nazi crimes. The major extermination centers, including **Auschwitz**, were liberated by the Soviet Red Army. The Western Allies met

Landing on Iwo Jima
American Marines are pinned down by Japanese fire on a beach of the volcanic island of Iwo Jima during the landings on February 19.



their most graphic experience of Nazi barbarity at **Belsen**, a concentration camp in Saxony. Liberating the camp in mid-April, British troops found thousands of prisoners dying of starvation, mistreatment, and disease, and bodies dumped in mass graves or left unburied. Cinema newsreel footage of Belsen convinced most people that the war against Germany had been justified.

The **human cost** of the war with Japan **continued to mount**. In February–March, US Marines

suffered 26,000 casualties capturing the island of **Iwo Jima**, a volcanic rock in the Pacific defended to the death by an 18,000-strong Japanese garrison.

The **American invasion** of the much larger **Okinawa Island**, launched in April, resulted in a bloodbath. Japanese soldiers as usual fought to the death and tens of thousands of the island's civilian population also died, many by suicide. The Allied fleet offshore was battered by **mass kamikaze attacks** (see 1944).

Meanwhile, American B-29 bombers began the **systematic destruction of Japanese cities**. An incendiary raid on Tokyo

on March 9–10 killed at least 80,000 people.

President Roosevelt did not live to see the defeat of Germany and Japan. The news of his **death** on April 12 came as a shock to the American people. The inexperienced **Harry S. Truman**, vice-president for less than three months, took over at the White House, facing formidable responsibilities.

The Allies had agreed that the Soviet Union should have the honor of **capturing Berlin**, and the heavy casualties that went with it. Hitler was determined to fight to the end, although much of the defense of Germany had devolved upon adolescents and the elderly. While American and Soviet troops advancing across Germany from west and east met amicably at the Elbe River, the Red Army fought street by street to take Berlin. As the Soviets drew near his bunker, on April 30 **Hitler shot himself**.

By then, former Italian dictator **Benito Mussolini** was also dead, **executed** by communist partisans.



Dresden in ruins
Inhabitants of the German city of Dresden attempt to cope with the aftermath of Allied bombing that created a firestorm in the city.



11.5 MILLION THE ESTIMATED NUMBER OF “DISPLACED PERSONS” IN EUROPE IN 1945

January 12 Soviet troops resume offensive in Poland and eastern Germany

January 22 F.D. Roosevelt inaugurated for fourth term as US president

February 3 US troops begin battle to retake Philippine capital Manila

February 13–14 Dresden destroyed by Allied bombing

February 19 US Marines land on island of Iwo Jima

March 9–10 American air raid on Tokyo causes firestorm that kills around 80,000 people

April 12 US President Roosevelt dies; he is succeeded by Harry S. Truman

April 25 Soviet and American troops meet at the Elbe River

April 30 Hitler commits suicide in Berlin

May 2 Soviet forces complete victory in battle for Berlin

May 7–8 Final German surrender ends war in Europe

January 27 Soviet Red Army liberates Auschwitz-Birkenau death camp

January 30 Wilhelm Gustloff sunk in the Baltic by a Soviet submarine, drowning 9,400 German refugees

February 4–11 Roosevelt, Churchill, and Stalin meet at Yalta

March 7 US troops seize bridge over Rhine at Remagen

March 8 Josip Broz Tito establishes provisional government in Yugoslavia

April 1 US troops land on Okinawa

April 15 Allied troops liberate Belsen and Buchenwald concentration camps

April 28 Benito Mussolini and his mistress killed by Italian partisans

June 5 Allied Control Council formally takes power in Germany

June 26 United Nations Charter signed by representatives of 50 countries